

Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

always acknowledge the ways in which external factors have played and continue to play a role in your relationship with money. Otherwise, you risk wasting valuable time and energy going round and round in circles, self-flagellating for things that aren't your fault. This is not about dwelling on your misfortunes or carrying a chip on your shoulder, just accepting and acknowledging those external forces at play in all of our lives and relieving yourself of any undue sense of responsibility for them.

Some of these external factors are systemic – they are built into the world in which we all have to operate, and they typically take a very long time to change. They affect us from childhood, providing a template for our relationship with money without us even really noticing until later on. There is still a huge gender pay gap, for example, which is greatly exaggerated for women of colour, and particularly Black women.¹

Some of the external factors are personal to you, but are still things that you have no control over – these are things such as the financial education you had access to, your upbringing and also any health issues that might make it more difficult for you to develop and maintain a good relationship with money. A good example of this is the fact that certain mental illnesses, such as bipolar disorder, and neurodiversities like ADHD, can make money management materially more difficult for the people who experience them. Another is the way that your parents or guardians discussed money at home, and how